

TOPIC 4: CULTURE AND IDENTITY

1. Meaning of Culture

Culture is the total way of life of a people. It includes their beliefs, values, customs, traditions, language, food, dressing, arts, music, and social behaviour that are passed from one generation to another.

Culture is learned, shared and dynamic (it can change over time).

2. Meaning of Identity

Identity refers to who a person is or how a person or group sees themselves. It includes personal identity (name, character, abilities) and social/cultural identity (ethnic group, language, religion, nationality).

Cultural identity is the sense of belonging to a particular culture or ethnic group.

3. Elements of Culture

The main elements (components) of culture include:

- **Language** – the means of communication (e.g. Hausa, Igbo, Yoruba, English).
- **Food** – traditional dishes (e.g. pounded yam, tuwo, jollof rice, edikang ikong).
- **Dressing / Clothing** – traditional attire (agbada, isiagu, baban riga, wrapper and blouse).
- **Religion** – beliefs and practices (Christianity, Islam, Traditional religion).
- **Values** – standards of behaviour (honesty, respect for elders, hospitality).
- **Customs and Traditions** – marriage rites, naming ceremonies, festivals.
- **Arts and Crafts** – music, dance, sculpture, pottery, weaving.
- **Technology and Tools** – traditional methods of farming, fishing, building.

4. Cultural Similarities and Differences

Similarities among Nigerian cultures:

- Respect for elders and parents.
- Importance of family and community.
- Celebration of festivals and ceremonies.
- Value placed on hospitality and sharing.
- Use of proverbs and oral tradition.

Differences among Nigerian cultures:

- Different languages and dialects.
- Different traditional dresses and food.
- Different marriage customs and naming ceremonies.
- Different traditional religions and festivals.
- Different systems of traditional leadership (Oba, Emir, Igwe, Obi).

5. Promoting Unity in Diversity

Nigeria is a multi-ethnic and multi-cultural nation. Unity in diversity means living together peacefully despite differences in culture, language and religion.

Ways to promote unity in diversity:

- Respect and tolerate other people's cultures and religions.
- Learn about and appreciate other cultures (e.g. through cultural days in school).
- Avoid ethnic or religious discrimination and hate speech.
- Promote inter-ethnic marriages and friendships.
- Use the national language (English) and national symbols to foster unity.
- Celebrate national festivals and events together.
- Teach children the values of patriotism and national integration.

6. Summary

Culture is the way of life of a people, while identity is the sense of who we are. Nigerian cultures have both similarities and differences. By respecting one another and promoting unity in diversity, we build a peaceful and progressive nation.

End of Topic 4 – Culture and Identity